

Panic Attack Management Instructions

Step-by-step instructions for managing a panic attack in the moment, based on evidence-based panic management technique.

How to Manage a Panic Attack in the Moment

- Recognize what's happening: Remind yourself this is a panic attack, not a heart attack or life-threatening emergency — it will peak within minutes and then pass.
- Practice slow, controlled breathing: Inhale through your nose for about 4 counts, then exhale through your mouth for 6-8 counts. Slower exhales help calm the body's stress response.
- Stay where you are if it's safe to do so: Leaving the situation can provide short-term relief but reinforces avoidance over time. Staying, if safe, helps the fear response naturally decrease.
- Let the sensations happen without fighting them: Accepting the physical sensations, rather than panicking about the panic itself, often shortens how long the episode lasts.
- Follow up afterward: Avoid using alcohol or sedatives to cope. If panic attacks become frequent or start restricting your daily activities, see a psychiatrist for evaluation.

When to seek urgent help

Seek urgent medical evaluation for a first-time attack, new chest pain, or symptoms you cannot confidently attribute to panic rather than a medical emergency. Seek psychiatric assessment if attacks become frequent or recurrent, or if fear of future attacks is starting to restrict daily activities.

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qualified mental health professional.

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